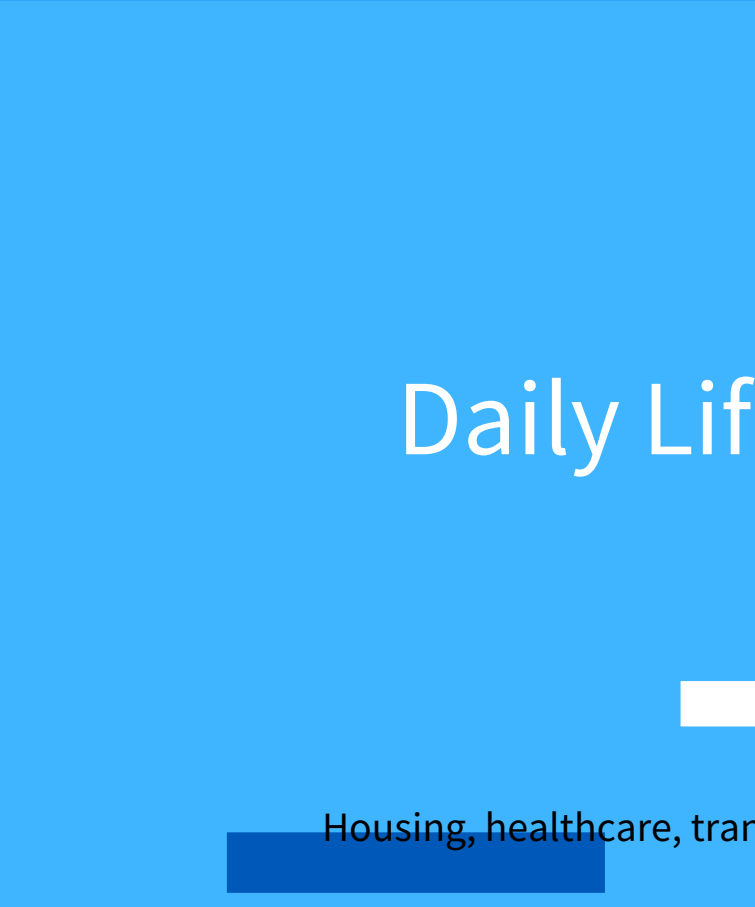
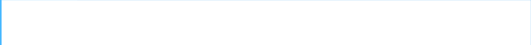
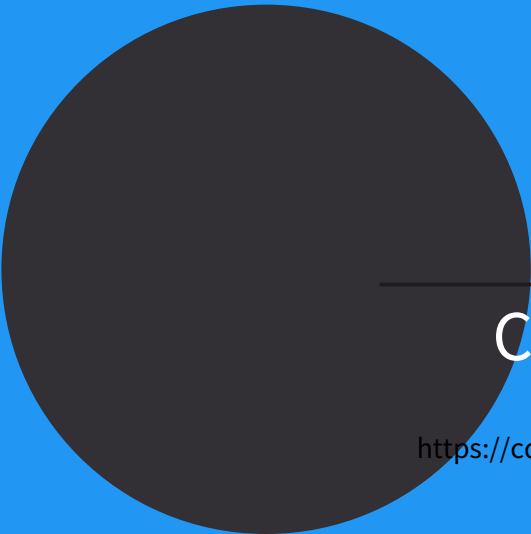




Daily Life in China



Housing, healthcare, transportation, and practical tips



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Daily Life in China

Housing, healthcare, transportation, and practical tips

Essential Apps Every Foreigner Needs in China (2026)

Living in China requires specific apps that most foreigners aren't familiar with. Here's your essential app guide.

Communication & Social:

- * WeChat (微信)

- * -- The #1 essential app. Messaging, payments, mini-programs, social media, government services. 1.3 billion users. Set up immediately upon arrival.

- * Weibo (微博)

- * -- China's Twitter. Follow news, celebrities, trending topics.

Payments:

- * Alipay (支付宝)

* -- Second major payment platform. Also used for utility bills, insurance, investments.

* Note: International credit cards can now be linked to WeChat Pay and Alipay for tourists.

Transportation:

* Didi (滴滴)

* -- China's Uber. Ride-hailing, taxi, and carpooling.

* Amap/Gaode (高德地图)

* -- Best navigation app in China (Google Maps doesn't work well).

* 12306

* -- Official train ticket booking app.

* Trip.com (携程)

* -- Hotels, flights, trains, attractions. English support.

Food & Delivery:

- * Meituan (美团)

- * -- Food delivery, hotel booking, movie tickets, local services.

- * Ele.me (饿了么)

- * -- Food delivery competitor. Often has different restaurant options.

- * Dianping (大众点评)

- * -- Restaurant reviews and ratings (like Yelp).

Shopping:

- * Taobao (淘宝)

- * -- China's Amazon. Everything imaginable, often at very low prices.

- * JD.com (京东)

- * -- Quality-focused e-commerce with fast delivery.

- * Pinduoduo (拼多多)

* -- Group-buying deals, very affordable.

Sources: Sources: [Government Services Portal](https://www.gov.cn) • [National Health Commission](http://www.nhc.gov.cn)

Opening a Bank Card in China: Complete Guide (2026)

A Chinese bank card is essential for daily life in China. Without one, you cannot fully use WeChat Pay or Alipay, receive salary payments, or pay rent. Here is everything you need to know about opening a bank account as a foreigner.

Why You Need a Chinese Bank Card:

- * Link to

- * WeChat Pay (微信支付)

- * and

- * Alipay (支付宝)

- * for seamless mobile payments

- * Receive salary payments from your employer

* Pay rent, utilities, and online shopping

* Transfer money domestically within China

For Students (学生)

Required Documents:

* Passport

* -- with valid student visa (X1/X2)

* Student ID (学生证)

* or Enrollment Certificate (在读证明) from your university

* Temporary Residence Registration (临时住宿登记表)

* -- obtained from the local police station within 24 hours of arrival

* Admission Letter (录取通知书)

* -- required by some banks for new students

Recommended Banks for Students:

* Bank of China (中国银行)

* -- Best for international transfers, widely used by international students

* ICBC (工商银行)

* -- Largest ATM network in China, convenient for withdrawals anywhere

* China Construction Bank (建设银行)

* -- Good campus branch coverage at major universities

Process:

* Go to a bank branch near your campus -- look for the foreigner service counter

(外币业务窗口)

* Fill out the account application form (开户申请表) -- staff can assist in English at major

branches

- * Get a queue number (排队号码) and wait for your turn
- * Open a basic savings account (储蓄卡/借记卡) with an initial deposit -- usually ¥10-50
- * Set up online banking (网上银行) and mobile banking (手机银行) during the same visit
- * Receive your UnionPay (银联) debit card on the spot in most cases

Tips for Students:

- * Bring a Chinese friend or classmate for translation -- not all branches have

English-speaking staff

- * Many universities organize
- * group bank card opening sessions
- * during orientation week -- take advantage of this
- * Your card can be linked to WeChat Pay and Alipay immediately after activation

* Keep your bank card number (卡号) and online banking credentials in a safe place

For Working Professionals (工作人士)

Required Documents:

* Passport

* -- with valid work visa (Z visa)

* Work Permit (工作许可证)

* or Employment Contract (劳动合同)

* Residence Permit (居留许可)

* -- issued by the local Public Security Bureau

* Company Introduction Letter (单位证明)

* -- a letter from your employer confirming your employment, stamped with the

company seal (公章)

* Temporary Residence Registration (临时住宿登记表)

Additional Requirements:

* Some banks require a

* Chinese phone number registered to your passport

* -- make sure your SIM card is under your own name

* You may need to provide a

* Tax ID (纳税人识别号)

* -- ask your HR department for this

Recommended Banks for Professionals:

* Bank of China (中国银行)

* -- Best for international transfers and receiving money from abroad

* ICBC (工商银行)

* -- Widest ATM network across China, good for frequent travelers within the country

* China Merchants Bank (招商银行)

* -- Best mobile banking app experience, excellent customer service

Process:

* Your employer may help arrange the bank account opening -- check with HR first

* Alternatively, go to a bank branch yourself with all required documents

* Fill out the account application and KYC (Know Your Customer) forms

* Open a

* salary account (工资账户)

* if your employer requires a specific bank for payroll

* Set up automatic salary deposit (代发工资) through your employer's payroll system

* You may qualify for a

* credit card (信用卡)

* after 6+ months of account history

International Transfers:

* Use your bank's

* SWIFT code

* to receive money from abroad -- Bank of China: BKCHCNBJ, ICBC: ICBKCNBJ, CMB:

CMBCCNBS

* The annual foreign exchange limit is

* \$50,000 USD equivalent per person

* Receiving money from abroad typically takes 1-3 business days

* You will need to visit the bank counter to convert foreign currency to RMB in some

cases

Common Tips for Everyone

* Always bring your passport -- you cannot open a bank account without it

* Bank hours:

* Monday-Friday 9:00-17:00

* , some branches open Saturday morning (9:00-12:00)

* Download your bank's

* mobile banking app (手机银行)

* for convenient transfers and balance checks

* A

* UnionPay (银联)

* card works at most ATMs and POS terminals across China

* Keep your bank card and password safe --

* never share your OTP (one-time password) with anyone

* If your card is lost or stolen, call your bank's customer service hotline immediately to

freeze the account

* Bank of China (中国银行)

* -- SWIFT: BKCHCNBJ -- Best for: International transfers

* ICBC (工商银行)

* -- SWIFT: ICBKCNBJ -- Best for: Widest ATM network

* China Construction Bank (建设银行)

* -- SWIFT: PCBCCNBJ -- Best for: Campus branch coverage

* China Merchants Bank (招商银行)

* -- SWIFT: CMBCCNBS -- Best for: Best app experience

Sources: Sources: Bank of China • ICBC • China

Construction Bank • China Merchants Bank • State Administration of Foreign Exchange

How to Borrow a Shared Power Bank in China (2026)

Shared power banks (共享充电宝) are everywhere in China -- at restaurants, malls, bars, airports, and train stations. If your phone is dying and you forgot your charger, these rental stations are a lifesaver. Here is how the system works.

What Are Shared Power Banks?

Shared power banks are portable battery packs housed in rental stations. You scan a QR code, pay a small fee, take a power bank with built-in cables, use it while you're out, and return it to any station of the same brand. It's as simple as renting a shared bicycle.

Major Brands

* 怪兽充电 (Energy Monster)

* -- Largest market share, found in most restaurants and shopping malls

* 街电 (Jiedian)

* -- Second largest, strong presence in convenience stores and cafés

* 小电 (Xiaodian)

* -- Popular in smaller shops and tea houses

* 来电 (Laidian)

* -- Often found in bars, KTV, and nightlife venues

* 美团充电宝 (Meituan Power Bank)

* -- Integrated with the Meituan app, convenient for Meituan users

How to Borrow

Method 1: WeChat or Alipay Scan

* Open

* WeChat

* or

* Alipay

* and scan the QR code on the rental station

* Authorize a security deposit -- usually

* ¥99-199

* (refunded when you return the power bank)

* A power bank pops out of the station -- take it and go

Method 2: Meituan App

* Open the

* Meituan (美团)

* app and search for "充电宝" (power bank)

* Find nearby power bank stations on the map

* Scan the QR code at the station to borrow

What You Get:

* Each power bank comes with

* built-in cables

* -- Lightning (iPhone), USB-C (Android/modern devices), and Micro-USB (older devices)

* Capacity is typically

* 5000mAh

* -- enough for roughly one full phone charge

* LED indicators show remaining battery level

Pricing

* First hour is often

* free

* or

* ¥1-2/hour

* After that,

* ¥2-4/hour

* Daily cap usually

* ¥20-30

* -- you won't pay more than this per day

* If you never return it, the deposit is charged and the power bank is yours to keep

How to Return

* Find any station of the

* same brand

* -- it does not have to be the same location where you borrowed

* Insert the power bank into an empty slot -- the rental ends automatically

* Your deposit is refunded and the final charge is calculated

* Use the app to find nearby return stations if you're in an unfamiliar area

Tips:

* Check battery level before borrowing

* -- most stations show LED indicators on each slot; avoid half-dead power banks

* Set a reminder to return

* -- charges add up over hours, especially overnight

* If you

* can't find a return station

* , contact customer service through the app -- they can help locate the nearest one

* NEVER return a power bank to a different brand's station -- a Jiedian power bank will

NOT fit in an Energy Monster station. Always check the brand name on the power bank

before walking to a return station.

* You can check the nearest return location for your brand through the brand's WeChat

mini-program (小程序) -- search for the brand name in WeChat and open the

mini-program to find nearby stations on a map.

* These stations are most common at:

* restaurants, KTV, shopping malls, airports, train stations, and bars

* If the power bank is

* damaged or not working

*, report it immediately through the app to avoid being charged

* Energy Monster (怪兽充电)

* -- ¥1-3/hour, daily cap ¥20 -- Found at: Restaurants, malls

* Jiedian (街电)

* -- ¥1-3/hour, daily cap ¥20 -- Found at: Convenience stores, cafés

* Xiaodian (小电)

* -- ¥2-4/hour, daily cap ¥30 -- Found at: Small shops, tea houses

* Laidian (来电)

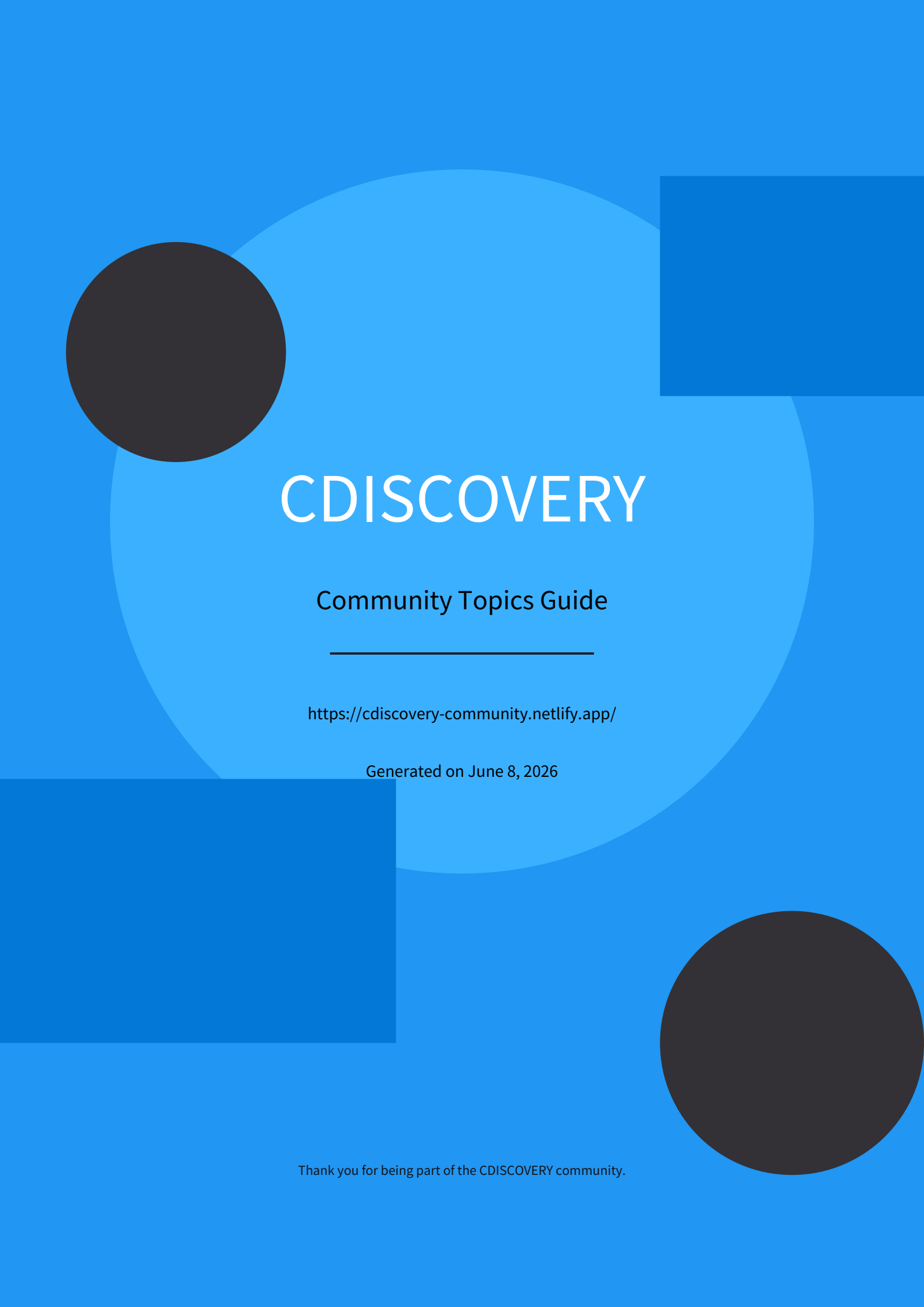
* -- ¥2-4/hour, daily cap ¥30 -- Found at: Bars, KTV, nightlife

* Meituan Power Bank (美团充电宝)

* -- ¥1-3/hour, daily cap ¥20 -- Found at: Meituan partner venues

Sources: Sources: 怪兽充电 Energy Monster • 街电 Jiedian • <a href="https://www.xiaodian.com"

target="_blank">小电 Xiaodian • 来电 Laidian

The background is a solid blue color. In the center, there is a large, light blue circle. To the left of this circle is a dark grey circle. To the right is a dark blue rectangle. Below the light blue circle is a dark blue rectangle. In the bottom right corner is a dark grey circle. The text "CDISCOVERY" is written in white, bold, sans-serif font across the center of the light blue circle.

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Community Topics Guide

<https://cdiscovery-community.netlify.app/>

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Thank you for being part of the CDISCOVERY community.